

VISCACHAS AND CHINCHILLAS

All six species of the family Chinchillidae from South America have a prominent tail and large hind feet. They normally live in social groups, inhabiting burrows or rocky outcrops. Most species are now quite rare because of their exploitation for fur and their status as pests.

CHINCHILLA

Chinchilla sp.

Widely prized for their fur, chinchillas have a fine, thick coat that insulates them against the cold in their Andean home.

22–38 cm
9–15 in

bushy tail
balances
the body

large ears help
regulate body
temperature

long whiskers
aid spatial
awareness

MOUNTAIN VISCACHA

Lagidium viscacia

This agile rodent has dense fur to protect it from the cold at night. It lives on steep, rocky, mountain slopes.

30–45 cm
12–18 in

DASSIE RAT

This single species in the family Petromuridae is found only in southern Africa. Its peculiar, flat skull and soft ribs are adaptations to living in crevices and under stones, and distinguish it from all other rodents.

DASSIE RAT

Petromus typicus

Living on dry, rocky hillsides, this rodent emerges from crevices at dawn and dusk to forage for seeds and shoots.

13–25 cm
5–10 in

CANE RAT

The two species of the family Thryonomyidae have pale brown, coarse, flattened hair that blends with their surroundings in dry grass and cane thickets. Cane rats produce two small families of well-developed young per year.

CANE RAT

Thryonomys sp.

There are two species of African cane rats: one lives in savanna grasslands and the other in reedbeds and marshes.

41–77 cm
16–30 in

PACARANA

The single species of the family Dinomyidae is a shy, bulky, slow-moving, and almost defenceless animal. It lives alone or in pairs in montane forests, where it is preyed upon by jaguars and humans.

PACARANA

Dinomys branickii

Threatened by loss of its S. American forest habitat, and hunted for food, the pacarana is now an endangered species.

70–80 cm
28–32 in

GUINEA PIGS, MARAS, AND CAPYBARA

Including some of South America's most widespread and abundant rodents, the Caviidae occur from mountain meadows to tropical flood plains, and breed all year round. All but the maras and capybara are short-legged and dumpy animals.

20–40 cm
8–16 in

BRAZILIAN GUINEA PIG

Cavia aperea

Guinea pigs mostly live in lowland habitats, but this species is also found in the Andes, from Peru to Chile.

20–40 cm
8–16 in

ROSETTE GUINEA PIG

Cavia porcellus

Several coat variations occur in pet guinea pigs. In this one, the fur forms substantial spiky whorls over the body.

20–40 cm
8–16 in

long ears

60–80 cm
23½–32 in

LONG HAIR GUINEA PIG

Cavia porcellus

Often kept as a pet, in captivity this long-haired breed needs grooming to prevent its fur from becoming tangled.

SHORT HAIR GUINEA PIG

Cavia porcellus

First domesticated more than 500 years ago for food, guinea pigs have since become popular pets worldwide.

20–40 cm
8–16 in

PATAGONIAN MARA

Dolichotis patagonum

Extensive shared burrow systems and communal breeding habits are among the unusual features of these long-legged rodents.